

I48

The thief on the cross

A dying criminal who asked Jesus to remember him and heard, "To day shalt thou be with me in paradise."

Two criminals were crucified with Jesus, one on each side. Matthew and Mark say both of them joined in mocking him. But Luke records that one of them spoke up. When the other railed at Jesus, he rebuked him: they were getting what they deserved, "but this man hath done nothing amiss." Then he turned to Jesus and asked, "Lord, remember me when thou comest into thy kingdom." Jesus promised that he would be with him in paradise that very day. We do not know his name, his crime, or his past. He could offer Jesus nothing but a request, and his story is one of Scripture's clearest pictures of grace.

At a glance

Name	Not given in Scripture. Tradition calls him Dismas
Called	A "malefactor" (Luke 23:32, 39) and a "thief" (Matthew 27:38, 44)
Crime	Not stated. He says his punishment is just (Luke 23:41)
Where	Golgotha, on a cross beside Jesus
When	c. AD 30, the day of the crucifixion
Known for	Asking Jesus to remember him; promised paradise
Main passages	Luke 23:32–43; Matthew 27:38, 44; Mark 15:27, 32

"And Jesus said unto him, Verily I say unto thee, To day shalt thou be with me in paradise."

Luke 23:43, KJV

The life of The thief on the cross

The date follows the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30; on the other main view, AD 33. Mark says Jesus was crucified at the third hour, and darkness fell from the sixth hour to the ninth (Mark 15:25, 33).

c. AD 30 Friday morning	● Led out with Jesus Two malefactors are led out with Jesus to be put to death. At the place called Calvary they are crucified, one on his right hand and the other on his left. <i>Luke 23:32-33</i>
On the cross	● Joins the mocking Matthew and Mark say that the thieves crucified with Jesus reviled him, joining the priests, the scribes and those passing by. <i>Matthew 27:44; Mark 15:32</i>
Before the ninth hour	● Rebukes the other One malefactor rails, "If thou be Christ, save thyself and us." The other rebukes him: they suffer justly, "but this man hath done nothing amiss." <i>Luke 23:39-41</i>
Before the ninth hour	● Asks to be remembered He says, "Lord, remember me when thou comest into thy kingdom." Jesus promises that he will be with him in paradise that very day. <i>Luke 23:42-43</i>
Before sunset	● Dies So that the bodies will not remain on the crosses on the sabbath, the soldiers break the legs of the two men crucified with Jesus. <i>John 19:31-32</i>

Group notes

Key activities

Matthew and Mark say both thieves reviled Jesus, while Luke says one did and one did not. Some think both mocked at first and one later changed; others think Matthew and Mark speak in general terms. The comma in Luke 23:43 is also debated. Most read "To day shalt thou be with me," while a few read "I say unto thee to day" as a solemn formula.

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- 1 **Faced the truth.** He admitted, "we receive the due reward of our deeds." *Luke 23:41*
 - 2 **Feared God.** He asked his fellow criminal, "Dost not thou fear God, seeing thou art in the same condemnation?" *Luke 23:40*
 - 3 **Defended Jesus.** In the middle of the mockery, he said Jesus had done nothing wrong. *Luke 23:41*
 - 4 **Called on Jesus as King.** He asked to be remembered when Jesus came into his kingdom. *Luke 23:42*
 - 5 **Received a promise.** Jesus assured him that he would be with him in paradise that day. *Luke 23:43*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names the thief on the cross.

Old Testament

Isaiah 53:12	"Numbered with the transgressors" (Luke 22:37; Mark 15:28 KJV)
Deuteronomy 21:22-23	A body must not remain on a tree overnight
Echo: Genesis 40:14	Joseph asks the butler, "think on me"

New Testament

Luke 23:32-43	The only account of his request and Jesus' promise
Matthew 27:38, 44; Mark 15:27-32	Two thieves crucified with Jesus revile him
John 19:18, 31-33	Jesus between the two; their legs broken
Echo: 2 Corinthians 12:4; Revelation 2:7	Paradise mentioned again
Echo: Matthew 20:1-16	Eleventh-hour workers receive full pay

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What three things did the repentant thief say (Luke 23:40-42)?
2. *Understand:* The thief could offer Jesus nothing but a request. What does Jesus' answer show about grace?
3. *Apply:* The thief admitted, "we receive the due reward of our deeds." What would honest confession to God look like for you this week?
4. *Apply:* Is there someone you have written off as beyond God's reach? How could you pray for them by name this week?